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Footnote

A note at the bottom of the page where its number is.

One note

The lamp-keepers of the northern coast kept a record of every evening they lit the harbor[1], and the record grew longer than the harbor itself. Most nights the third column stayed empty, and the keepers took pride in that.

Several notes on a page

The oldest keeper claimed that she could tell the season from the smell of the oil alone[2], and she was seldom wrong. Nobody could say when the first entry was made[3], only that the ink in it had faded to the color of weak tea. When a storm did come, the entries ran past the margin[4] and onto the back of the page.

Under the lamp room stood a cupboard of spare wicks, glass chimneys and one brass bell that nobody remembered buying. A page of the record was ruled into three columns: the hour, the weather, and a line for anything worth remembering. Visitors who read the record in order noticed that the handwriting changed every few years, while the weather never did.

Most nights the third column stayed empty, and the keepers took pride in that, since a quiet night meant a safe one. Nobody could say when the first entry was made, only that the ink in it had faded to the color of weak tea. When a storm did come, the entries ran past the margin and onto the back of the page, written in a hurried hand.

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Keepers who stayed on the coast for many winters learned to read the record the way a sailor reads a chart. A page of the record was ruled into three columns: the hour, the weather, and a line for anything

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[1] The record is kept in the museum at the old customs house, in forty volumes.

[2] Whale oil in winter, colza in spring, and later the paraffin the lighthouse board sent.

[3] The first leaf is lost; the earliest entry that can be read is from the autumn of 1811.

[4] Some are written crosswise over the ruling, and a few *on the back of the page*.

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worth remembering. The last column held what the keepers could not leave out: a ship lost on the bar[5], a child born in the lamp room, or the winter the harbor froze from the pier to the point.

On the next page

A note keeps to the page of its number. When the notes of a page would crowd out the line they belong to, the line moves to the next page, with its note[6], and the page before it ends a little early.

[5] The brig Alder, in the November gale of 1834; the keeper rang the brass bell until morning.

[6] This note is on the second page, with the number that stands in the line above it.

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A section of its own

The numbers of the notes start over in a section, so the note of this text is the first again[1], and it stands at the bottom of this page.

[1] Numbered 1, though the section before it has six notes.